CHATTING AS LONG AS POSSIBLE

Till You Get Bored

— • —

forty-four long conversations about everyday life

JAD

Beirut, Lebanon

Chatting as Long as Possible: Till You Get Bored

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This is a work of fiction. All characters and events in this book are fictional. Any resemblance to real people is coincidental, unless it made you laugh—in which case, it was probably on purpose.

First edition, 2026

Beirut, Lebanon

A Note on How This Book Was Made

Every conversation in this collection was written by the author. The manuscript was then divided into chapters, given chapter titles, edited for spelling, grammar, and punctuation, and prepared for print with the help of Claude, an AI assistant made by Anthropic. Where two chats happened to share a character's name, one of them was given a new name so that every character in the book is their own person. The voice, the jokes, the randomness, and the people in these chats are entirely the author's own; the assistance was limited to structure, proofreading, and formatting.

A Note from the Author

This book is what daily life looks like for an average guy on planet Earth—and for all the ordinary people around him. It showcases the ups, the downs, and the boring daily routines of people on this planet: the friend who falls for a neighbor she has seen only once this year, the father counting to three at the front door, the girl who buys a fish and forgets its name a month later, the two friends on a rooftop waiting for a sunset and a lighter. I wrote this book to show readers how life can simply be enjoyed, whether you look at it from a perfectly average perspective or a hopelessly overcomplicated one. You might find it funny, even hilarious. You might find it serious, uncomfortable, or a little demeaning in places. But it is here to play a role: to help build some small part of the future in this era, a present with a dash of the past. It keeps alive what is already gone, and it keeps life rolling. In my opinion, that is what builds a sustainable life. These chats show that human interaction is still very much a thing, and that it will never be lacking, even with all the technology around us and everything it has brought. Even with everything happening around the world—wars, pollution, disruption—people still sit across from one another and talk. I hope this book helps build what it takes to make a better future for the generations coming up, or at the very least, serves as a reminder of what our past as humans was actually like.

My first book, *The 15-Minute Chats*, kept its conversations short. This one lets them run. Each chat here goes on for as long as it possibly can—through the detours, the silences, the second thoughts, the phone calls nobody wanted, and the moments when someone finally gets up and walks out—until you, the reader, get bored. I'm hoping you won't.

I'm a computer and communications engineer by training and a web developer by trade, but the thing I keep coming back to, again and again, is people talking. Bear with me if my tone comes across as a bit judgmental in places; I promise that's not the point. The point is the conversation itself. I hope these chats put a smile on your face, or at the very least, make you wonder.

About This Book

Chatting as Long as Possible is a companion to *The 15-Minute Chats*, and like its older sibling, it is not a novel in the traditional sense. There is no single hero and no plot to keep track of. Instead, there are forty-four conversations between forty-four different sets of people, each one complete on its own.

The difference is length. These chats don't stop at the punch line. They follow people out the door, across the street, into the car, through the night, and into the next morning. A crush turns into a confession at a restaurant table. A bedtime standoff turns into a kitchen argument about whose money it really is. A man asks his friend for coffee and leaves with an offer to join a kidney empire. Two friends go fishing on a lake and argue, at length, about sharks.

Some of these chats are light and silly. Others go to darker places, with strong language and grown-up situations, because real conversations sometimes do. All of them are fictional, and all of them are built on the same belief that runs through everything I write: that ordinary people talking to each other is still one of the most interesting things in the world.

Read it front to back, or open it anywhere and drop in. Just keep going for as long as you can.

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CHAPTER 1

The Neighbor Across the Street

———

Gloria: I think I'm in love.

Casey: Really? With whom?

Gloria: With my neighbor…

Casey: But you've never met him. And you rarely see him. In fact, you've only seen him once this year!

Gloria: It's a feeling, Casey!

Casey: Well, I feel like dancing. Do I go around saying I want to dance?

Gloria: You can.

Casey: You're missing the point. We humans have feelings, but it's not our feelings that lead us. It's our cognitive function.

Gloria: Well, my brain and my heart both say I love this guy. What are you going to do about it?

Casey: It's not me, Gloria. It's your parents. They warned you about him, and you'd better listen!

Gloria: I'm going to say it again, more clearly. I LOVE HIM!

Casey: I warned you. That's all I'm going to say.

Gloria: Let's go out!

Casey: Where do you want to go?

Gloria: The place across the street.

Casey: Oh, really? To see your neighbor?

Gloria: Yeah, sure. Why not…

Casey: Fine, but you'd better keep me entertained.

Gloria and Casey head to the restaurant across the street.

Casey: Do you want to sit inside or outside?

Gloria: Isn't it obvious? Outside, to keep an eye out.

Casey: I should have known.

Gloria: Move the chair, please.

Casey: Bite me!

Gloria: It's your chair.

Casey: Sure! Why not…

Gloria: Do you see him?

Casey: Actually, yes. Isn't that him, the guy walking over there?

Gloria: That's the garbage man.

Casey: I should have known.

Gloria: No, really! Do you see him?

Casey: I told you, right across the street, behind the garbage man. Isn't that him?

Gloria: Oh, yes, it is…

Casey: And?

Gloria daydreams.

Casey: AND?

Gloria: Jeez! What? Yes?

Casey: And what do we do now?

Gloria: Well, now… nothing, really.

Casey: Nothing?

Gloria: Yes, nothing!

Casey: Nothing it is!

Gloria: Shut up… shut up… Here he comes.

Casey: Done!

Gloria: Lower your voice!

Casey: Oh, hi, dear neighbor! We're just visiting this place for the first time. What do you recommend? And I still didn't get your name… Henry?

Harry: It's Harry, actually… I'd recommend the smoothies here. They're great!

Casey: Well, thanks! We'll give them a try… What else?

Harry: The ice cream is good as well.

Casey: Oh, really… We'll check it out for sure.

Harry: Sure thing. And let me know what you think of them later on.

Casey: We will… Thanks again, Hen… Harry. I meant Harry. Thanks again.

Harry: Anytime.

Casey: That went well, right?

Gloria: I didn't say a thing.

Casey: And?

Gloria: I didn't say a thing… What do you mean, "and"?

Casey: Grow up…

Gloria: You made me look like a child.

Casey: No, I didn't.

Gloria: Yes, you did.

Casey: He's not that good-looking anyway.

Gloria: Yes, he is…

Casey: Do you still love him?

Gloria: What does that have to do with anything?

Casey: I'll get you some tea. I didn't like his recommendations.

Gloria: Sure!

Gloria's phone starts to ring.

Gloria: It's my dad.

Casey: Well… answer it.

Gloria answers the phone.

Gloria: Hello! Oh, hi, Dad…

Gloria's Dad: Where are you?

Gloria: Who, me? Well, I'm right across the street.

Gloria's Dad: Alone?

Gloria: With Casey…

Gloria's Dad: With whom?

Gloria: I can't hear you, Dad. I'll call you when I'm done, okay?

Gloria's Dad: Sure!

Gloria: Bye.

Gloria hangs up.

Casey kisses Gloria.

Gloria: What was that?

Casey: Nothing!

Gloria: What is wrong with you?

Casey: Nothing!

Gloria: Leave me alone, you creep…

Casey: It was nothing, really!

Gloria leaves Casey.

Casey: That didn't go as expected.

Random Guy: Not the worst.

Casey: How would you have done it better?

Random Guy: I don't know.

Casey: You don't know?

Random Guy: What do you want me to say…

Casey: I don't know. Some real advice would really help.

Random Guy: Okay. Don't give up on her, man.

Casey: Really?

Random Guy: She'll love you eventually… And if she doesn't, there are plenty of fish in the sea.

Casey: But I want this fish…

Random Guy: Oh… love.

Casey: Thanks!

Random Guy: Anytime!

CHAPTER 2

Count to a Million

———

Edward: Get inside…

Willy: Later. I'm busy.

Edward: I said get inside.

Willy: What if I don't?

Edward: I said get inside!

Willy: No!

Edward takes a deep breath.

Edward: I'm going to count to three, and I want to see you inside. Okay?

Willy: Count to a million. A gazillion… I'm not coming.

Edward: Okay, I tried. Leave, in that case.

Willy: I'm going, and I'm never coming back.

Edward: Good. I don't care.

Willy: Bye!

Edward: Bye!

Willy keeps walking outside and hears a dog barking.

Edward: Are you coming?

Willy: As fast as I can…

Edward: Hurry up…

Willy runs inside and jumps onto a chair.

Edward closes the door.

Edward: TV?

Willy: iPad.

Edward: Sure.

Willy: Hey, I just wanted to say…

Edward: What?

Willy: Nothing. It's nothing…

Edward: No, I'm listening.

Willy: Thanks!

Edward: Anytime!

Willy: No, really… thank you.

Edward: You're most welcome… iPad, you said, right?

Willy: Yes!

Edward: YouTube or Minecraft? What are you going to use it for?

Willy: Photos. I'm going to look at photos.

Edward: None of my business, but here you go.

Willy takes the iPad.

Jenny: You know he's lying about looking at photos. You know that.

Edward: At least he's not gambling or watching porn.

Jenny: Gambling isn't that far-fetched.

Edward: With those games he plays, give him a couple of years and he'll be gambling our savings away.

Jenny: Your savings, dear, not mine…

Edward: Hey! My money is my money…

Jenny: It's our money.

Edward: Are you sure about that?

Jenny: Pretty sure.

Edward: Well, I love you.

Jenny: That doesn't change anything, dear.

Edward: Aren't you going to say it back?

Jenny: I love you. Happy?

Edward: I love the sound of that. Shows a bit of respect.

Jenny: Get out!

Edward: I'm in my own home. Where do you want me to go?

Jenny: I meant out of my kitchen.

Edward: You need to ask nicely.

Jenny: Piss off, and get out.

Edward: Nicely…

Jenny: Please, get out.

Edward: Better…

Jenny: OUT!

Edward leaves.

Jenny: Jeez Louise, I thought he'd never leave.

Derek: So did I.

Jenny jumps and starts screaming.

Jenny: Dear Lord…

Derek: I came to get popcorn. Bye.

Derek grabs the popcorn and leaves.

Jenny: This boy…

Willy: He's something, isn't he?

Jenny: Yeah, he is.

Willy: Can I play outside?

Jenny: It's ten o'clock. Go to bed!

Willy goes outside.

Jenny: Hey!

CHAPTER 3

Have Faith, Little Terry

———

Denise: What a beautiful little child!

Victor: Isn't he? Do you like his name?

Denise: Terry? Isn't it a bit old-fashioned, as they say?

Victor: No, not at all. It's still very common.

Denise: Well, I love him either way.

Victor: That's nice.

Denise: He has your eyes, too.

Victor: Does he?

Denise: And your ears, and your round face.

Victor: Really?

Denise: Look at him, dear. He's your child. What, do you think he's mine?

Victor: Indeed he is.

Denise: Well, I have to leave.

Victor: Stay for dinner. Why leave so early?

Denise: I have to go to church and pray for little Terry here. Isn't that right, little one?

Victor: Do you think he's really my child?

Denise: Who else's could he be? Have faith in God. He's yours and always will be yours. Don't worry about what people say. You're foolish to think otherwise.

Victor: But I heard the neighbor say he's special because he has a scar, and only special people have scars.

Denise: Then aren't you special, dear? Aren't you as important as the people with scars, even if you don't have one?

Victor: I guess?

Denise: Well, get a grip on yourself and be confident. He's yours. Have faith in God.

Victor: Really?

Denise: Look at it this way: if it weren't for your dad, you wouldn't be here, and if it weren't for you, this child wouldn't be here either. Do you understand?

Victor: Kind of…

Denise: It's the cycle of life, dear. It's all meant to be. Just enjoy the ride and don't worry, okay?

Victor: Deal.

Denise: Well, I have to leave. I'm late for church. Love you, dear, and more love to you, sweet little Terrance.

It is raining.

Denise goes out the door, holding an umbrella.

Victor: Pray for us.

Denise: I will…

CHAPTER 4

Who Do I Love?

———

Pamela: Do you pray at night?

Christie: I always pray at night…

Pamela: No, really?

Christie: It depends…

Pamela: It depends on what?

Christie: It depends on each day that passes by.

Pamela: Well, good night, Christie.

Christie: Wait, before you go to sleep, can we play a game?

Pamela: Good night, Christie!

Christie: Let's at least talk some more.

Pamela: I said good night.

Christie: Good night.

The next day.

Pamela: Good morning, Christie.

Christie: I want to go out.

Pamela: That's a good idea, but say good morning first.

Christie: Morning.

Pamela: Where do you want to go?

Christie: For a walk around the neighborhood.

Pamela: Sure. Good idea.

Pamela and Christie walk down the street next to their house.

Pamela: What did you want to tell me last night?

Christie: Last night?

Pamela: Before we went to sleep.

Christie: Nothing, really. I was just bored.

Pamela: Do you have any guy friends, or any crushes, dear Christie?

Christie: Like a boyfriend?

Pamela: Kind of. At least a friend.

Christie: None.

Pamela: Really?

Christie: Well, a guy held my bag for me the other day at the grocery store.

Pamela: Nice. That's something.

Christie: It's nothing, really.

Pamela: At least guys are trying to get to know you.

Christie: I don't have feelings for anyone.

Pamela: Except?

Christie: Except you!

Pamela: Ha-ha… Do you want to go back home?

Christie: Actually, no. I want to keep walking.

Pamela: Well, I'm tired, and I'm going back.

Christie: I'll go around the block and come back in a bit.

Pamela: It's cold. Don't you want to go back now?

Christie: I won't be long.

Pamela: Suit yourself.

Pamela leaves.

Christie is alone.

Christie: Who do I love? I love cereal with milk… I think that's enough.

CHAPTER 5

At Least Till You're Eighteen

———

Anna: Which box do you want?

Calvin: The one on the right.

Anna: That one's taken.

Calvin: The one on the left?

Anna: Also taken.

Calvin: Well, that leaves me with the one in the middle. I don't want that one, but I'll take it.

Anna: Here you go.

Calvin: How much?

Anna: It's a vape, dear boy. You've got to show me an ID first.

Calvin: Right, right… Here. I'm eighteen.

Anna looks at the ID.

Anna: You're fifteen.

Calvin: Wait, I'll pay double.

Anna: That's a special vape.

Calvin: Triple…

Anna: It's not about the money, dear boy. It can hurt you in the long run.

Calvin: I'm willing to take the risk.

Anna: You're fifteen.

Calvin: Here's a hundred. Just please, please give me one.

Anna: If you put it that way…

Calvin: Come on, I'm your customer.

Anna: Look, I'm going to take fifty from you, but this is the last time.

Calvin: Thank you, thank you…

Anna: At least till you're eighteen.

Calvin: Deal!

Anna: Or seventeen or something. I swear, this is the last time.

Calvin: The last time…

Anna: Do you want anything else? I can give you a pack of nicotine gum for twenty.

Calvin: That would be great!

Anna: Do you have a girlfriend, boy?

Calvin: Actually, I do, yes.

Anna: Here's a flower… Tell her it's from your aunt Anna. She'll love it.

Calvin: Sure. Why not?

Anna: Here's your change, thirty. Stay safe, and use what I gave you wisely.

Calvin: I'll use it wisely.

Anna: Good to know. Now leave my shop before I call the cops… Ha-ha, I'm kidding. Go on, boy.

Calvin leaves.

CHAPTER 6

Hollywood Style

———

Owen: Let's film a movie.

Barry: About what?

Owen: About our lives.

Barry: No kidding. And what will it be about?

Owen: What we've been through, and our travels.

Barry: There's not much to them, and they're not that interesting.

Owen: Are you sure? Have you seen the posts on Instagram?

Barry: Okay…

Owen: Do you see my point?

Barry: I do, but they're not movie-worthy…

Owen: Yes, they are!

Barry: Do you actually want to make a movie?

Owen: I know a producer. We tell him this and that, and boom, a movie.

Barry: A movie for us to watch? Sure, I'd agree to that.

Owen: No, a real movie.

Barry: You mean Hollywood style?

Owen: Yes!

Barry: You're out of your fucking mind, and I'm leaving.

Owen: Don't… wait.

Barry: What?

Owen: Don't you love me, my guy?

Barry: What does that have to do with anything?

Owen: Let's finish the movie and go on one last trip.

Barry: And where exactly would that be?

Owen: Yemen.

Barry: Bye!

Owen: Come on… it'll be fun.

Barry: Bye, you fucking idiot.

Owen: Bye, then.

CHAPTER 7

Too Risky

———

Lilian: I stole a credit card.

Rebecca: Well, that's good. Do you have the PIN?

Lilian: No.

Rebecca: Do you know whose it is?

Lilian: No.

Rebecca: How did you get it?

Lilian: I stole it…

Rebecca: What the fuck!

Lilian: I stole it. Who cares? Now, how are we going to get some money?

Rebecca: We go to the ATM and take some out.

Lilian: Too risky, and we don't know the PIN…

Rebecca: Then we use it to pay for food and clothes and so on.

Lilian: Also too risky…

Rebecca: Let's go on a trip far, far, far away and use it there.

Lilian: Good idea.

Rebecca: Or get rid of it.

Lilian: Hey, why?

Rebecca: Too risky…

Lilian: Let's sell it, then.

Rebecca: Good idea.

Lilian: Online?

Rebecca: Also too risky.

Lilian: I don't know, and I don't care anymore.

Rebecca: Hey, you're the one who got it!

Lilian: Well, I wish I hadn't!

Rebecca: GO TO HELL!

Lilian: YOU GO TO HELL!

Rebecca: FINE!

Lilian: AT LEAST I'LL BE GOING WITH A CREDIT CARD!

Rebecca: FINE!

Lilian: FINE!

CHAPTER 8

A Welcome Gift

———

Nile: I have a gift.

Enzo: For whom?

Nile: You!

Enzo: How thoughtful! What for?

Nile: Just a welcome gift.

Enzo: Ohhh…

Nile gives Enzo the gift.

Enzo: Is it a box of flowers?

Nile: No!

Enzo: Ha-ha… I'm just kidding.

Enzo opens the gift.

Enzo: Ohhh, it's a watch.

Nile: It sure is…

Enzo starts crying.

Enzo: Thanks, man!

Nile: No need to cry. It's just a watch.

Enzo: It's the thought that counts, my guy… It's the thought that counts.

Nile: Well, you're most welcome.

Enzo: Let's grab a cup of coffee, okay? On me.

Nile: Okay, if you say so…

Enzo: Thanks again!

Nile: Anytime.

CHAPTER 9

It's Just a Show

———

Tony: Get a grip on yourself.

Elsie: Why? Because I'm a girl?

Tony: It's just a show, and you're acting like it's a tragedy.

Elsie: But they loved each other.

Tony: So what?

Elsie: And now they're both dead.

Tony: So what?

Elsie: Don't you get it? Don't you have feelings?

Tony: I'll say it again: it's just a show. Move on, and stop crying in front of all these people.

Elsie: Leave me alone! I want to cry. You can't stop me!

Tony: Okay, fine! Cry. But I'm leaving…

Elsie: Hey! You can't leave me alone.

Tony: I'll be waiting in the car. When you're done crying, please come back to the car so we can leave.

Elsie: I love this show!

Tony: I know. That's why I'm leaving.

Elsie: I love you too, you know.

Tony: I know. That's also why I'm leaving.

Elsie: Jerk.

Tony: Come back when you're done, my love.

Elsie: Jerk.

Tony: I heard you the first time.

CHAPTER 10

Mrs. Q

———

Claire: I think I want to buy a fish.

Stacey: A fish? Isn't that a bit boring? Why not a dog or a cat?

Claire: Fish remind me of the sea, and I like the sea.

Stacey: Get an aquarium and buy several fish.

Claire: Let's start with one and see.

Stacey: What kind of fish are you getting?

Claire: A clownfish?

Stacey: Good, but not that fun.

Claire: A starfish?

Stacey: Needs a lot of care.

Claire: I've got it. A pufferfish.

Stacey: I mean…

Claire: It's perfect.

Stacey: It is, but then you'll need to get an aquarium fast. One of the huge ones.

Claire: I will, if I like the fish.

Stacey: You'll love it. I had one myself.

Claire: I saw a place online that sells everything we need.

Stacey: Let's order one.

Claire opens her phone.

Claire: This one's good, for a reasonable price.

Stacey: Buy it, then…

Claire: It can arrive with a bowl in thirty minutes.

Stacey: Buy it!

Claire: I bought it… We're getting a fish!

Stacey: We're getting a fish…

Thirty minutes later, the doorbell rings.

Claire: It's the fish.

Stacey: Open the door!

Claire opens the door and takes the fish and the bowl.

Claire: Thank you!

Stacey: We have a fish! We have a fish! What are you going to name it?

Claire: Q, for Queen.

Stacey: Hello, Mrs. Q! You're so pretty. Oh, yes, you are.

One month later.

Stacey: Claire, your fish died. What did you name it again?

Claire: I don't know. Q, I think.

Stacey: Right. Well, too bad.

CHAPTER 11

The One and Only Rope

———

Jasmine: Here you go. That's five dollars.

Neo: Do you have rope?

Jasmine: Yes, it's right out back in the…

Neo: I mean rope. Rope.

Jasmine: Yes! Out back in the…

Neo: No, I mean this kind of rope.

Neo shows Jasmine a picture.

Jasmine: Oh!

Neo: Do you have it?

Jasmine: I'd better call 911.

Jasmine picks up the phone, but Neo stops her.

Neo: Please, if you have this kind of rope, just tell me. I don't want to cause any trouble.

Jasmine: Just look out back.

Neo: Thank you!

Neo goes out back.

Neo: Rope, rope, rope… Where's the rope? Oh, here.

Police sirens sound in the distance.

Neo: Shit, I'd better leave. Oh, here it is.

Police Officer: Hey! Stop!

Neo escapes.

Neo: I'll pay for it later. Bye!

Jasmine: Thief!

Neo: Later!

Neo runs out the back.

Neo hides behind the dumpster.

Neo: At least I got what I wanted. The one and only rope.

CHAPTER 12

You Don't Know How to Mop

———

Lydia: Don't you know how to clean, my dear?

Erika: What? Am I doing it wrong?

Lydia: Yes, you are!

Lydia grabs the mop, and its wooden handle snaps near the bottom.

Erika: Happy?

Lydia: It's because you don't know how to clean!

Erika: Well, now no one can clean, because you broke the mop.

Lydia: There's another one. Wait here.

Lydia gets another mop.

Erika: Oh!

Lydia: Let me show you. You get all around the edges, left and right, and everything in between. And you don't just mop once. In some cases, you mop a second time to make it extra clean. Are you listening to me?

Erika: I know how to mop!

Lydia: Show me, then!

Erika: I'm leaving!

Lydia: Show me!

Erika: Bye!

Lydia: You don't know how to mop!

Erika: YES, I DO!

Lydia: Coward!

Erika closes the door.

Lydia: How is she ever going to get married? She's driving me crazy!

CHAPTER 13

I Hate Dogs

———

Zoey: I'm enjoying this.

Mia: You mean the ride?

Zoey: Yes. The car ride, the fresh air, the convertible, the seaside…

Mia: Do you want me to go faster? I can go faster if you want.

Zoey: Sure. Why not?

Mia presses down on the gas pedal.

Zoey leans out the window, her hair flying.

Zoey: Woo-hoo!

Mia: Are you enjoying this?

Zoey: A lot!

Mia: Get back inside.

Zoey: In a bit.

Mia: Where do you want to eat?

Zoey: The place you told me about.

Mia: Sure!

Mia pulls up to the place she told Zoey about.

Mia: Get out. We're here.

Zoey: I'm coming.

Mia opens the door to the restaurant and sees a dog.

Mia: I hate dogs.

Zoey: Come on, it's just a dog. Let's go inside.

Mia: You first.

Zoey: Big whoop!

Mia and Zoey take a window seat.

Mia: I'm going to the bathroom.

Zoey: Okay!

Mia goes to the women's bathroom.

Mia hears barking.

Mia leaves the women's bathroom.

Mia goes into the men's bathroom.

Mia: I'd better hurry.

Mia sees a guy in the men's bathroom.

Mia: Oh, hi. There was a dog, and... I'd better leave.

Mia sees another guy.

Mia: Hi!

Mia leaves the men's bathroom.

Mia goes back to Zoey.

Zoey: That was fast.

Mia: It sure was.

Zoey: The food is here.

Mia: That's a good sign.

Zoey: What?

Mia: Nothing. Let's eat.

Zoey: Thanks!

Mia: Anytime. Don't mention it.

CHAPTER 14

Maybe Another Time

———

Richard: I bet you have what it takes.

Richard throws a ball to Fred.

Fred catches the ball.

Fred: To be a professional golfer? I have a thing or two.

Richard: But do you know how to swing a club the way you throw a ball?

Fred throws the ball to Richard.

Richard catches it with ease.

Fred: I'm telling you, I can handle it.

A plane passes overhead.

Richard: I'm going to take a shower.

Fred: We just started.

Richard: Well, I'm getting old and tired.

Fred: Do you want to have some drinks?

Richard: Cocktails, that kind of stuff?

Fred: Yeah, sure.

Richard: Wait till I finish my shower, and we'll get to it.

Fred: Sure. Why not?

Richard sings in the shower.

Fred stands at the bathroom door.

Fred: Look, man, maybe another time.

Richard stops singing and calls back to Fred.

Richard: Suit yourself. Bye.

Fred: Bye!

CHAPTER 15

Half a Man at Most

———

Qwen: I love men.

Ken: What?

Qwen: You heard me. I love men.

Ken: Okay? And what does that have to do with anything?

Qwen: It means I love you.

Ken: I like the sound of that.

Qwen: Once you become a man.

Ken: I am one.

Qwen: Don't flatter yourself, honey. You're still a little boy.

Ken: Hmmm.

Qwen: You have nothing to say for yourself?

Ken: I don't really care. I know I'm a man.

Qwen: Well, good luck with that.

Ken: I'm leaving.

Qwen: What? Did you get offended?

Ken: No, I'm just busy. And as you know, men are always busy.

Qwen: How charming. You dazzle me with your words.

Ken: So you consider me a man.

Qwen: Half a man, at most.

Ken: I'll take it.

Qwen: And what do you consider me?

Ken: You don't want to know.

Qwen: Come on, tell me.

Ken: Words cannot describe it.

Qwen: Oh!

Ken leaves Qwen.

Ken is alone.

Ken: How ugly your soul is, and how charming you are.

CHAPTER 16

Everything Is Closed

———

Isabella: I work in this building.

Naya: Which floor?

Isabella: Fourteen.

Naya: What are you, in HR?

Isabella: An assistant.

Naya: Can I go up and take a look around?

Isabella: It's better if we get going.

Naya: Come on, five minutes.

Isabella: It's Sunday. Everything's closed. You won't see a thing.

Naya: Then let's go to the mall. It's right around the corner.

Isabella: Yeah, sure. Why not?

Naya and Isabella walk around the corner to the mall.

Naya: It's closed.

Isabella: Oh!

Naya: Where do we go now?

Isabella: The drugstore. I need to get some wipes.

Naya: I know one across the street.

Isabella: Let's go.

Naya and Isabella cross the street to the drugstore.

Naya: It's closed too.

Isabella: You're such bad luck.

Naya: Am I?

Isabella: With you, there's no luck in anything.

Naya: Really? At least I'm married.

Isabella: Well, I have a boyfriend.

Naya: It's your tenth boyfriend, Izzy.

Isabella: Well, I like him.

Naya: Well, good luck.

Isabella: I'm leaving. I can't handle this.

Naya: Where are you going? The car is up the hill.

Isabella: I'm taking a cab.

Isabella takes a cab and leaves.

Naya stands alone on the street.

Naya: What a bitch.

CHAPTER 17

See You on the Other Side

———

George: Are you enjoying the run?

Ben: A lot.

George: I've been running since I was a kid.

Ben: We all run, George. Almost every single person has been running since they were a kid.

George: No, I mean I've been running 5Ks, 10Ks, and half marathons since I was a kid.

Ben: Wow!

Ben takes deep breaths.

George: What, are you tired?

Ben: No.

George: Do you want to stop?

Ben: No, let's keep moving. I can take it.

Ben takes even deeper breaths.

George: I think we'd better stop.

Ben: I'll stop. You keep going.

George: Nah, man. I'll wait for you.

Ben: You don't have to.

George: It's fine. I'll wait.

Ben and George stop.

George: Did you buy that necklace I told you about?

Ben: You mean the one with the flowers?

George: That's the one.

Ben: I did, I did.

George: And?

Ben: It's perfect.

George: I told you you'd like it.

Ben starts walking.

Ben: I think I'm going to walk back.

George starts running.

George: See you on the other side!

Ben: See you!

CHAPTER 18

Downtown Girls Have No Patience

———

Clara: I love getting my nails done.

Diana: Me too.

Clara: Are you enjoying getting your nails done right now?

Diana: I love it.

Clara: Do you want to go to the villa when we're finished?

Diana: Where is it?

Clara: It's close by.

Diana: I'm almost done. I'll wait for you outside.

Clara: Sure! Why not?

Diana's nails are finished, and she waits outside for Clara.

Diana: She's taking way too long. I think I'm going to leave.

Diana tells her chauffeur to take her back home.

Clara, her nails finished, goes outside to meet Diana.

Clara: Where are you going?

Diana: I think I'm done for the day. I'm going home.

Clara: But the villa…

Diana: Later.

Diana leaves Clara.

Clara: Downtown girls have no patience at all.

Store Owner: They sure don't.

Clara: Oh, I haven't paid yet! I'm sorry, so sorry.

Store Owner: Good thing you remembered to pay for your nails.

Clara: How could I forget?

Clara takes out her purse. There is no money inside.

Store Owner: That'll be 110 dollars, please.

Clara: Credit cards? Do you take credit cards?

Store Owner: You're lucky we do.

Clara: Oh! Thank you!

CHAPTER 19

Unregistered

———

Maggie: I bought a gun.

Zack: Okay? And what do you want to do with it?

Maggie: I don't know. I just bought it. It was a good price.

Zack: Is it registered?

Maggie: No.

Zack: Then get rid of it.

Maggie: I'm a girl, and I live alone!

Zack: This is a city. People can help you if anything goes wrong.

Maggie: You mean cops?

Zack: Yes, I mean cops.

Maggie: My dad is a cop, and I don't trust him.

Zack: There are others who can help you, like security guards, agents, and so on… Why buy a gun?

Maggie: I only trust myself.

Zack: Get out. I don't want some girl with an unregistered gun staying in my room!

Maggie: I'M YOUR FRIEND!

Zack: OUT!

Maggie leaves the room with the gun and closes the door.

Zack: I'm calling for help. She can't have a gun.

Zack calls 911.

Zack: I want to report someone with an unregistered g… Never mind, never mind. I was mistaken. Bye.

Zack hangs up.

Zack takes deep breaths.

Zack: FUCK!

CHAPTER 20

Be Romantic at Least Once

———

Sandy: Buy me something.

Lewis: Like what?

Sandy: We're in a store, aren't we?

Lewis: Yes, we are.

Sandy: Then buy me something.

Lewis: A bottle of water?

Sandy: A bottle of water?

Lewis: Aren't you thirsty?

Sandy: I said buy me something. Dazzle me with it. Be romantic.

Lewis: It's the end of the month. What do you want me to say?

Sandy: It doesn't have to be expensive… Try being romantic at least once in your life.

Lewis: I've got it! This flower… How much is this flower, dear lady?

Cashier: We don't sell flowers. You can take it for free.

Lewis: Here you go, sweet Sandy. Something romantic.

Sandy: Only this?

Lewis: Do you want chocolate? I can get you a box of chocolates.

Sandy: Really?

Lewis: Yes! I insist… How much is the box of chocolates, dear lady?

Cashier: Seven dollars.

Lewis: I'll buy it. Here you go, my sweet Sandy…

Sandy: You're such a gentleman.

Lewis: Well, I listen to what my dear love tells me to do.

Sandy: I love you, dear.

Lewis: Same here.

Sandy: Aren't you going to say it?

Lewis: Say what?

Sandy: "I love you"?

Lewis: I said it. "Same here."

Sandy: It's not the same!

Lewis: Okay, I love you. Happy?

Sandy: Now we can go. But hold my hand first.

Lewis: Dear God.

Sandy: I said hold it!

Lewis holds Sandy's hand.

Lewis and Sandy leave the store.

CHAPTER 21

I Paid Everything

———

Kane: I live here.

Harper: I'm sorry, sir, but you're being evicted.

Kane: But I paid everything.

Harper: These are just orders, sir. Please don't blame me. You can talk with the owners to find out what's wrong.

Kane: That's bullshit.

Harper: Sir, language, please.

Kane: Language, my ass. I paid everything.

Harper: Five minutes and we're done. There's no need to take it out on us.

Kane pushes Harper.

Kane: Get out of my place.

Harper is shocked.

Kane: GET OUT!

Harper leaves with her assistant.

Kane: I paid everything, you hear me? TELL THE OWNERS I PAID EVERYTHING!

Harper is scared.

Harper: Okay.

Kane: Good, good. That's good.

CHAPTER 22

Two Papers

———

Stephan: Do you like games?

Vanessa: A lot.

Stephan: Rock, paper, scissors?

Vanessa: Sure. Why not?

Stephan: On "shoot."

Vanessa: Deal.

Stephan: One, two, three, shoot!

Vanessa: I win.

Stephan: What was that?

Vanessa: Two papers, with both hands.

Stephan: But I threw scissors.

Vanessa: You cut my first paper, and I blocked you with the second paper.

Stephan: You can't do that.

Vanessa: Yes, I can.

Stephan: I don't care. It's not right.

Vanessa: Think again.

Stephan: That's not how the game is played.

Vanessa: Sure it is.

Vanessa presses both hands over Stephan's face.

Vanessa: This is how we play the game…

Stephan: Nah… ugh!

Vanessa: I can't hear you, dear. I can't hear you, my love, my sweet, sweet love!

CHAPTER 23

Pack Your Bags

———

Yoda: Pack your bags. We're leaving.

Jean: But I love it here.

Yoda: These are orders. I'm not arguing with you.

Jean: But the farm…

Yoda: We're leaving now.

Jean: You don't understand.

Yoda: No! You're the one who doesn't understand.

Jean: But why?

Yoda: Don't you read the news? Haven't you seen what's happening around you?

Jean: But…

Yoda: We've got to go. Now hurry.

Jean: But…

Yoda: Hurry!

Jean goes inside, packs her bag, and comes back to Yoda.

Yoda: Have you got your passport?

Jean: Yes!

Yoda: Let's go.

Jean: Where are we going?

Yoda: Somewhere far, far away.

Jean: Where is that?

Yoda: Far, far away.

Yoda gets in the car.

Yoda: Come on, get in.

Jean gets in the car.

Yoda: Far, far away.

CHAPTER 24

Build Me a Bridge

———

Frank: Build me a bridge.

Henry: Where?

Frank: Here.

Henry: I'll take a look around, but it's going to take a while.

Frank: Take all the time you need.

Henry: That easily?

Frank: What? What's wrong?

Henry: You can't just tell me to build you a bridge and expect it ready the next day.

Frank: I said take your time.

Henry: Well, I have to think it over first.

Frank: What is there to think over?

Henry: It's a big project.

Frank: Don't worry about funding. I've got you.

Henry: But…

Frank: But what?

Henry: But who's going to work with me?

Frank gets in his car.

Frank: You'll have to figure that out yourself.

Henry: A bridge?

Frank: Yes!

Henry: When will I see you again?

Frank: When it's all over.

Henry: Who's going to check on the site?

Frank: I'll send people.

Henry: That's it?

Frank: Yes!

Frank drives away.

Henry: A bridge. A fucking bridge.

CHAPTER 25

Say It

———

Randy: Get me out!

Luna: I will, as soon as you admit that you love me.

Randy: Get me out, now!

Luna: I love you!

Randy: That's nice. Now get me out.

Luna: Say that you love me!

Randy: I won't.

Luna: Then you're not getting out.

Randy pushes hard against the door.

Luna: SAY IT!

Randy pushes the door harder.

Luna: SAY IT!

Randy breaks the door down.

Luna: SAY IT!

Randy hugs Luna.

Luna: Why didn't you say it?

Randy: I love you.

Luna is overjoyed.

Luna hugs Randy.

Randy: Do you want some water?

Luna: Yes, please.

Randy: Let's go get some water.

CHAPTER 26

On the Next Ride

———

Andy: I love listening to music.

David: Really? What kind?

Andy: All kinds of music.

David: I love jazz.

Andy: I love that.

David: I have records at my place.

Andy: So do I.

David: Do you want to swap?

Andy: Swap what, exactly?

David: Jazz records.

Andy: Yeah, sure. Why not?

David: Do you remember the old days?

Andy: How could I forget?

David: We were so young.

Andy: And foolish.

David: No need to mention that.

Andy: I miss the old days.

David: Not as much as I do, my friend.

Andy: Really?

David: Not as much as I do.

Andy: Will we ever go back?

Andy and David get up to catch the bus.

David: On the next ride, my friend. On the next ride.

CHAPTER 27

Don't Panic

———

Dimitri: I have kids, yes.

Hannah: Oh, me too.

Dimitri: How many children do you have?

Hannah: Two. A boy and a girl.

Dimitri: Well, I have a boy and a girl as well.

Hannah: In that case, they've got to meet.

Dimitri: My children are over there.

Hannah: I don't know where mine went.

Dimitri: They must be in the playroom.

Hannah: I'll go check.

Hannah goes to the playroom.

Dimitri calls out to his kids in the playground.

Dimitri: Come on, kids, we've got to go.

Hannah comes back from the playroom.

Hannah: I couldn't find them.

Dimitri: They must be here somewhere.

Hannah: Where's the coordinator?

Dimitri: Don't panic. You'll find them. I'm sure of it.

Hannah: Thank you!

CHAPTER 28

To the Roof

———

Barney: I bought a pack of cigarettes.

Paul: I bought whiskey.

Barney: To the roof!

Paul: To the roof we go.

Paul and Barney take the elevator to the roof.

Barney: This view is to die for, man.

Paul: Do you want to watch the sunset?

Barney: Let's call up some girls, my guy.

Paul: None of them will come. Especially your type of girls.

Barney: I could stay up here all day, my guy.

Paul: Give me the pack, please.

Barney: Yeah! Sure. But I forgot the lighter.

Paul: Then go get it.

Barney leaves the rooftop to get a lighter.

Paul calls his girlfriend.

The phone rings, but there is no answer.

Paul sends her a voice note.

Paul: Call me when you're free.

Barney knocks on the rooftop door.

Barney: Paul, I'm back. Open up, my guy.

Paul drinks from the bottle of whiskey.

Barney: Paul! Paul! Paul! Come on, open up, my guy!

CHAPTER 29

The Planet of Zara One

———

Jason: I write books for a living.

Dona: What kind of books?

Jason: The kind that keep you up all night.

Dona: I'd like to get a copy of one of those.

Jason: Do you like to stay up all night?

Dona: It depends.

Jason: It depends on what?

Dona: On whether someone is beside me or not.

Jason: Well, I write thrillers.

Dona: That's nice.

Jason: I have a book right here. My highest-rated one yet.

Dona: Really?

Jason hands Dona his book.

Jason: Enjoy.

Dona: I like romance.

Jason: It has a bit of romance in it.

Dona: I'd really appreciate that.

Jason: It's mostly a thriller, but it has everything in it. All kinds of genres. Just read it. You'll love it.

Dona: *What's It Like on the Planet of Zara One?* Wow.

Jason: Wait for *Zara Two*. It's coming out soon.

Dona: I can't wait.

CHAPTER 30

The Kidney Business

———

Isaac: The system is down.

Gerrard: Then we'll wait.

Isaac: Can't you do something about it?

Gerrard: For the time being, no.

Isaac: Do you want to go get some coffee?

Gerrard: From the place downtown?

Isaac: Yeah, that one.

Gerrard: Any idea why the other one closed?

Isaac: The one on the lower floor? Not sure. Probably because it was always out of order.

Gerrard and Isaac go to the coffee place downtown.

Gerrard: I love this place.

Isaac: Not as much as I do.

Gerrard: Do you have any idea how much it costs to buy a kidney?

Isaac: A lot. But why?

Gerrard: I think I want to buy one.

Isaac: No kidding…

Gerrard: I want to start a business.

Isaac: What are you, a mad scientist?

Gerrard: I believe in this shit. I studied in med school for three years before I switched to business.

Isaac: And?

Gerrard: And I want to build an empire.

Isaac: Of selling kidneys.

Gerrard: It can be done legally.

Isaac: I'm not so sure. But why? Stick to something worthwhile.

Gerrard: Like what?

Isaac: Buying property… TikTok… anything but kidneys.

Gerrard: You're not getting it.

Isaac: No, I'm getting it. I'm feeling your vibe, my friend, and what I have to say is: get a life. Like a hobby or something. I'm telling you right now, I'm not getting involved in this business.

Gerrard: You'd be my first customer.

Two men in suits drag Isaac out of the coffee shop.

Gerrard: And, hopefully, the most precious.

CHAPTER 31

Just Doing My Business

———

John: I'm leaving.

Donald: It's one in the morning. Sleep here for the night.

John: I still have to go shopping tomorrow.

Donald: You can go tomorrow afternoon. No big deal. Sleep here for the night.

John: I live close by. No need.

Donald: I insist. Stay. We're enjoying your company.

John: Okay, but I've got to go to the bathroom first.

Donald: Sure.

John goes to the bathroom.

John calls his mom.

John: I'm not coming home tonight, okay, Ma? I'll see you tomorrow… Bye, Ma. Bye.

Donald knocks on the bathroom door.

Donald: Is everything all right in there?

John: Just doing my business.

Donald walks away from the door.

John opens the window and jumps out.

John starts running down the street.

John: Just doing my business.

CHAPTER 32

Just a Peek

———

Darelle: I want to buy a gun.

Rosa: You can buy mine.

Darelle: How much does it cost?

Rosa: A few thousand.

Darelle: That's too much.

Rosa: What were you expecting?

Darelle: I don't know. Five hundred?

Rosa: That's not the kind of gun I own.

Darelle: Seven hundred fifty at most, and that's it.

Rosa: Do you want to see it?

Darelle: Maybe later. I've got to go.

Rosa: Come on, just a peek.

Darelle: It's upstairs in your room, isn't it?

Rosa: Yes! Follow me.

Rosa and Darelle go upstairs to Rosa's room.

Rosa finds her gun and hands it to Darelle.

Rosa: Here it is.

Darelle: Wow. I could play Russian roulette with this piece of equipment.

Rosa: Let's do it, then.

Rosa takes the gun and aims at the door. Then she spins the cylinder and pulls the trigger.

CHAPTER 33

The Floor Is Lava

———

Noel: Grab my hand.

Dean: What for?

Noel: The floor is wet. You've got to jump over to my side. Come on.

Dean: Okay! Chill.

Dean grabs Noel's hand and jumps to the other side.

Noel: The floor is lava!

Dean: Do you want to play that game?

Noel: You mean the floor-is-lava game?

Dean: Let's start. On three, we jump to the other side.

Noel: Okay!

Dean: One, two, three…

Noel and Dean jump to the other side.

Noel: I win.

Dean: How?

Noel: You touched the wet floor.

Dean: One–nothing?

Noel: Technically, you lost.

Dean: No fair.

Noel: Do you want to play another game?

Dean: Just leave me alone.

Noel: GG, my friend.

Dean leaves Noel.

Noel: GG.

CHAPTER 34

These Small Arguments

———

Alex: I've got chips. Do you want some?

Lexy: No, thanks. I'm on a diet.

Alex: Are your eyes green or blue? I still can't tell.

Lexy: Neither. They're hazel.

Alex: That's what I said before.

Lexy: Before what? You never said that.

Alex: Before we met.

Lexy: Really?

Alex: I mean, you're still beautiful.

Lexy: Thanks!

Alex: That's it? "Thanks"?

Lexy: What do you want me to say? That you're beautiful as well? You're a boy!

Alex: What's wrong with that?

Lexy: Fine, fine. You're beautiful.

Alex: Thank you very much.

Lexy: You're most welcome.

Alex: See? That wasn't so hard.

Lexy: It sure wasn't.

Alex: Chips?

Lexy: Yeah, sure. Why not…

Lexy takes a chip from Alex.

Lexy: I'll miss this.

Alex: Taking chips from me and breaking your diet?

Lexy: That, yes. But most of all, these small arguments.

Alex: You're totally right.

CHAPTER 35

My Future Is Here

———

Katie: Let's talk inside.

Peter: But I have something I've got to tell you.

Katie: Inside.

Katie and Peter go into a room.

Katie: What did you want to say?

Peter: I got a ticket to go back home.

Katie: And?

Peter: I can get you one too.

Katie: Go on…

Peter: We go home and use the money we've made to build a future for us.

Katie: Go on…

Peter: Look, here's the ticket.

Peter shows Katie the ticket.

Katie: And?

Peter: And it's what we've wanted since five years ago. Aren't you convinced?

Katie hands Peter back the ticket and points to the door.

Katie: Get out.

Peter: Really?

Katie: Out, now!

Peter: What's wrong with you?

Katie: LEAVE ME ALONE! OUT, NOW!

Peter leaves Katie alone.

Katie: My future is here.

Katie looks at the camera in the corner of the room.

Katie: It will always be here.

CHAPTER 36

We Wait

———

Kevin: I like this song.

Amy: Let's dance.

Kevin and Amy go out on the dance floor.

Kevin: What do you do for fun?

Amy: Dancing, I guess.

Kevin: You're a really good dancer.

Amy: Check out this move.

Amy pushes Kevin away and dances solo.

Kevin: Wow.

The song ends, and Kevin and Amy stop dancing.

Kevin tries to kiss Amy.

Amy slaps Kevin.

Kevin: But I like you.

Amy: I like you too, but not now.

Kevin: We wait?

Amy: We wait.

Kevin: What now?

Amy: Hold my hand.

Kevin and Amy hold hands.

CHAPTER 37

A Dollar and a Sunset

———

Patrick: Do you have a dollar?

Megan: How much?

Patrick: A dollar.

Megan gives Patrick a dollar.

Megan: Do you want more?

Patrick: No, no… That'll do.

The vending machine whirs.

Patrick takes a Snickers bar out of the vending machine.

Patrick: Here you go.

Megan: Thanks! Let's find somewhere to sit.

Patrick: The bench over there has a view.

Megan: Sure!

Patrick and Megan sit on the bench and watch the sunset.

Patrick: I always come here when I feel lonely.

Megan: Really?

Patrick: When life was hard, this was the only solace I had.

Megan: Well, I have my cat.

Patrick: I have a pet hamster.

Megan: Is it fluffy?

Patrick: I had a pet hamster. It died two weeks ago.

Megan: My condolences.

Patrick: Thanks!

Megan: Anytime.

CHAPTER 38

It's a Bugatti

———

Graham: She's beautiful.

Fedora: Who, me? Well, I just showered and did my hair, so, yeah. Thanks!

Graham: Such beauty!

Fedora: Oh!

Graham: Can I get in?

Fedora: Graham! What's wrong with you, dear?

Graham: The car, honey, the car. I want to get inside the car.

Fedora: I mean, you can, but you don't admire my beauty.

Graham: I've always admired your beauty, but it's time to be realistic, dear… It's a Bugatti.

Fedora: What is wrong with you?

Graham: I like cars. What can I do?

Fedora: More than your wife.

Graham: I mean…

Fedora: You jerk!

Fedora leaves.

Graham: Honey!

CHAPTER 39

Happily Married

———

Quinn: Kiss me.

Daniel: On the lips?

Quinn: Yes!

Daniel kisses Quinn on the lips.

Quinn: See?

Daniel: See what?

Quinn: You're not gay.

Daniel: I know that.

Quinn: But I proved it.

Daniel: Do you want to go again?

Quinn: What are you, a psycho? Besides, I'm married.

Daniel: Well, to whom, exactly?

Quinn: I'm not just married. I'm happily married.

Daniel: Do I know this guy?

Quinn: You do. He's your brother.

Daniel: You bitch!

Daniel tries to slap Quinn.

Quinn grabs Daniel's hand.

Quinn: Never try that again!

Quinn lets go of Daniel's hand.

Daniel: What is wrong with you?

Quinn: What can I do? I like men.

CHAPTER 40

First Day

———

Arnold: Who are you?

Remy: I'm an engineer. I work here.

Arnold: I've never seen you in my life.

Remy: Well, it's my first day, and I work in the lower department.

Arnold: What's your name?

Remy: Remy.

Arnold and Remy shake hands.

Arnold: Arnold.

Remy: Nice to meet you.

Arnold: Same here! What do you do, exactly?

Remy: System design.

Arnold: I work in construction.

Remy: Well, see you around. I'm in a bit of a hurry, actually.

Arnold: Excuse me, then! See you around, dear Remy.

Remy: See you!

Remy and Arnold walk off in opposite directions.

Remy: And you never will, my friend. And you never will.

CHAPTER 41

The Towel Is Still Dry

———

Lizzy: You smell weird.

Walter: I just showered.

Lizzy: No, you didn't.

Walter: I shower every day.

Lizzy: More like once a week.

Walter: Prove it!

Lizzy: The towel is still dry.

Walter: That doesn't prove anything.

Lizzy: I'm too busy to argue. Where do you want to go today?

Walter: To the park?

Lizzy: Let's go.

Lizzy and Walter go to the park.

Lizzy and Walter start walking around the park.

Walter: I want to get married.

Lizzy: To whom?

Walter: I like a girl.

Lizzy: Who is she?

Walter: Who cares who she is? I want to get engaged, married, dating, a relationship, friends… I want something, goddamn it!

Lizzy: You'll get it. You're an outstanding young man, and every girl would dream of you. You're responsible, understanding, caring, and, most importantly, you know how to act.

Walter: Wow!

Lizzy: But you smell like shit, so let's deal with that first.

Walter: You're such a bitch sometimes.

Lizzy: I just had to say it.

CHAPTER 42

It's Coming on Tuesday

———

Gary: I bought this watch.

Emily: What does it do?

Gary: It's a watch… What can it do? It tells time, Emily. It tells time.

Emily: I don't know… It could be a smartwatch.

Gary: It's an ordinary watch, okay? Okay, dear?

Emily: Can I see it?

Gary: Sure you can.

Gary hands Emily the watch he just bought.

Emily: Wow!

Gary: It's black, I know, but it looks cool. I bought it with my end-of-service pay. I thought I'd treat myself to something here and there.

Emily: You could have bought us a dishwasher.

Gary: I did that as well.

Emily: Well, I don't see it.

Gary: It'll be here on Tuesday… next week.

Emily: Thanks, dear!

Gary: Anything to provide for my family.

The following Tuesday.

Emily: Dear, where's the dishwasher?

Gary: It's coming, dear.

CHAPTER 43

It's a Lake

———

Michael: Let's go fishing.

Scott: First thing tomorrow.

The next morning, Michael and Scott go fishing on the lake.

Michael: I'm enjoying this.

Scott: What are the odds?

Michael: The odds of what?

Scott: What are the odds we catch a shark?

Michael: Slim to none. We're on a lake, my guy.

Scott: I mean a shark.

Michael: None! I repeat, there are no sharks here, my guy.

Scott: Okay, okay. There are no sharks.

Michael: Good.

Scott: What about a dolphin?

Michael: My guy! It's a fucking lake!

Scott's fishing pole starts to bend.

Michael: Start pulling, Scott… Start pulling!

Scott pulls.

Michael: Don't jump in the water, okay?

Scott jumps in the water.

Michael: I said don't jump in the water, you idiot!

CHAPTER 44

You Surprise Me

———

Molly: I can't swim.

Paula: I'll guide you.

Molly and Paula jump in the water and start swimming.

Paula: See? That wasn't so hard.

Molly: I hate the water.

Paula: You drink water.

Molly: I hate being in the water.

Paula: That's fair, but swimming isn't that difficult.

Molly: It sure isn't.

Paula: I've been swimming my whole life.

Molly: I've been playing the piano my whole life.

Paula: You could teach me.

Molly: You could teach me as well.

Paula: In that case, we could teach each other.

A phone rings.

Paula: It's mine. I've got to answer. I'll be right back.

Paula leaves Molly alone in the pool.

Molly slips and drifts into the deep end.

Molly starts swimming on her own.

Paula: I'm coming, Molly!

Paula jumps in right beside Molly to help her.

Molly: I almost got the hang of it.

Paula: You sure did.

Molly: Do you want to go get some ice cream?

Paula: I'd rather have crepes.

Molly: I could do that.

Paula: You surprise me, dear Molly. You surprise me.

About the Author

Jad is a twenty-four-year-old computer and communications engineer and web developer based in Beirut, Lebanon. By day, he builds software; in whatever hours are left over, he collects conversations—the weird ones, the amusing ones, and the everyday ones that quietly turn into life lessons without warning.

He grew up with a fairly average late-nineties-and-two-thousands childhood, full of the kind of constant, casual, in-person human interaction that his generation took for granted. He has watched that kind of interaction grow rarer over the years, which is part of what drew him to write books built entirely out of talking.

Outside of engineering and writing, Jad produces short-form content under the handle @jad, aimed at putting smiles on people's faces, especially in the weirdest and most unexpected situations, and he writes about current events in Lebanon. *Chatting as Long as Possible* is his second book, following *The 15-Minute Chats*.

Acknowledgments

Thank you to everyone who ever kept a conversation going long after it should have ended. This book exists because of all of you.

Thanks also to Claude, the Anthropic AI that helped divide this manuscript into chapters, give each chat a title, clean up the spelling and grammar, give new names to a handful of characters so that no two chats share one, and prepare the book for print—a small but real part of how it came together.